

EMPOWERING ENGINEERS UK

Feedback & Coaching Guide

1. OVERVIEW (FEEDBACK.HTML)

Effective technical leadership relies on the ability to develop personnel and manage team performance through structured communication. The UK-SPEC assesses these interpersonal and leadership qualities under Competence C (Responsibility, management or leadership) and Competence D (Communication and interpersonal skills). The Feedback & Coaching hub provides developing engineers with digital workbenches to practice giving and receiving constructive, objective feedback.

2. STRUCTURING CONSTRUCTIVE FEEDBACK

Delivering feedback in high-pressure engineering environments can be fraught with misinterpretation. Providing actionable, fact-based critiques is essential for maintaining safety and project velocity.

- **SBI (Situation-Behaviour-Impact):** A critical framework for objective feedback. It trains engineers to isolate the specific context (Situation), describe the observable action (Behaviour) without judgment, and state the tangible project or team consequence (Impact). This removes emotional bias from technical reviews.
- **CEDAR (Context-Examples-Diagnosis-Action-Review):** A collaborative review architecture. It encourages dialogue by diagnosing root causes (e.g., training gaps vs. negligence) before co-authoring an action plan, ensuring the stakeholder takes ownership of the correction.
- **COIN Model (Context-Observation-Impact-Next Steps):** A rapid-deployment feedback structure ideal for fast-paced operational corrections. It swiftly moves from observing the error to defining the immediate next step to resolve the risk.

3. COACHING AND PERSONNEL DEVELOPMENT

Beyond correcting errors, CEng and IEng applicants must demonstrate they can actively mentor and grow the capabilities of junior engineers and technical teams.

- **GROW Model (Goal-Reality-Options-Way Forward):** The foundational coaching structure. It guides a coachee from defining their career or project ambition (Goal), assessing their current technical baseline (Reality), exploring potential training or project assignments (Options), and committing to specific actions (Way Forward).
- **Pendleton's Rules:** A balanced dialogue technique that forces the receiver to evaluate their own performance first ("What went well?", "What could be improved?"). This fosters self-awareness and reflective practice—key tenets of professional engineering.

4. DEMONSTRATING INTERPERSONAL SKILLS FOR UK-SPEC

During the Professional Review Interview (PRI), panels look for evidence that a candidate can manage conflict, negotiate with stakeholders, and foster a culture of continuous improvement.

By utilising the frameworks within the Feedback hub, candidates can transition from vague statements like "I told my team to work better," to verifiable leadership examples: "I observed a recurring design error. Using the SBI framework, I addressed the issue with the drafting team, diagnosing a lack of software training, and implemented a GROW-based coaching plan to upskill the junior members, resulting in a 30% drop in drawing revisions."

5. CONCLUSION

The Feedback & Coaching module equips developing engineers with the communication architecture necessary to build high-performing, safe, and aligned technical teams. Mastering these frameworks generates the explicit leadership evidence required to satisfy the interpersonal and management criteria of the Engineering Council.